Malshej Ghat, Maharashtra

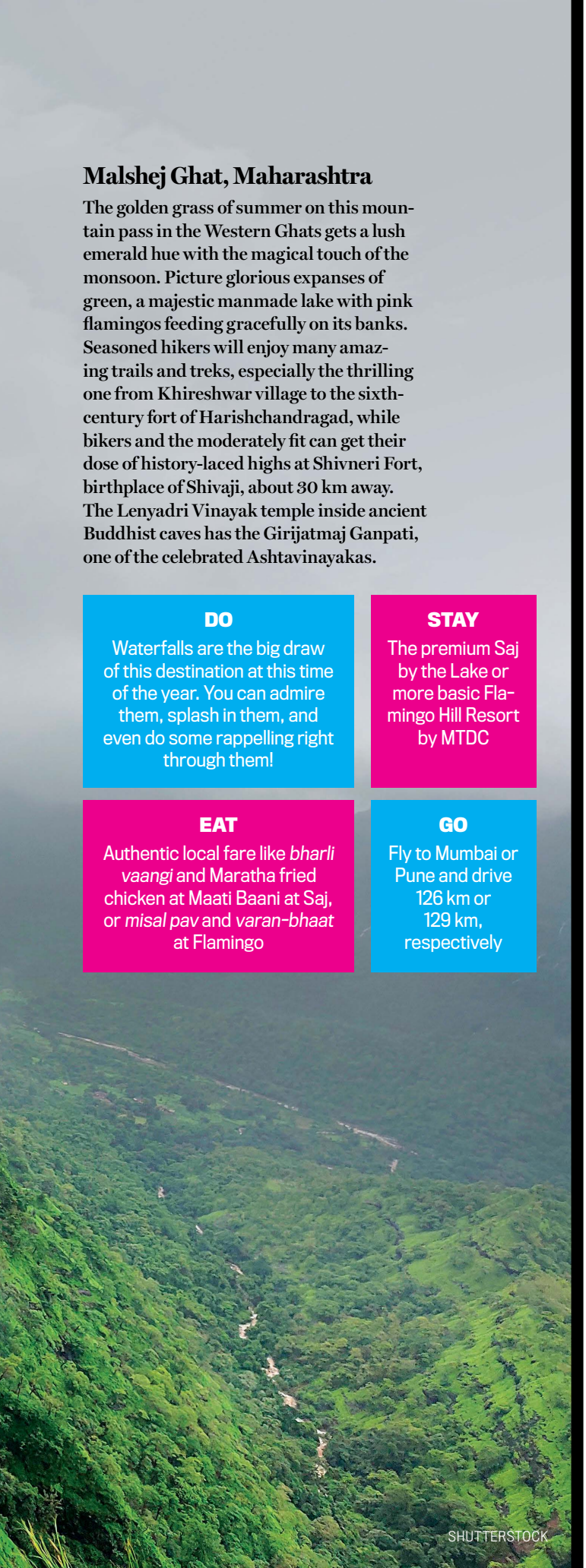
The golden grass of summer on this mountain pass in the Western Ghats gets a lush emerald hue with the magical touch of the monsoon. Picture glorious expanses of green, a majestic manmade lake with pink flamingos feeding gracefully on its banks. Seasoned hikers will enjoy many amazing trails and treks, especially the thrilling one from Khireshwar village to the sixth-century fort of Harishchandragad, while bikers and the moderately fit can get their dose of history-laced highs at Shivneri Fort, birthplace of Shivaji, about 30 km away. The Lenyadri Vinayak temple inside ancient Buddhist caves has the Girijatmaj Ganpati, one of the celebrated Ashtavinayakas.

DO
Waterfalls are the big draw of this destination at this time of the year. You can admire them, splash in them, and even do some rappelling right through them!

STAY
The premium Saj by the Lake or more basic Flamingo Hill Resort by MTDC

EAT
Authentic local fare like *bharli vaangi* and Maratha fried chicken at Maati Baani at Saj, or *misal pav* and *varan-bhaat* at Flamingo

GO
Fly to Mumbai or Pune and drive 126 km or 129 km, respectively



SHUTTERSTOCK

Mawsynram, Meghalaya

In a state that is literally called the 'abode of the clouds', first Cherrapunji (Sohra) and now Mawsynram (just 15 km away) have been declared as the wettest places on earth. June 17 last year saw Mawsynram receiving a record-setting 1,003.6 mm of rainfall in just 24 hours. Waterfalls such as Nohkalikai and Seven Sisters are especially awe-inspiring when fed by the torrential rains. Visit the hilltop village of Mawlyngbna to see fossils or indulge in some ziplining. The Mawjymbuin cave, which has a stalagmite 'shivling', is best accessed after the monsoon.



SHUTTERSTOCK

DO The double-decker living root bridge, only a 3-km trek from the village of Tyrna, is worth a visit in any season, but especially magical in the rains

EAT Khasi delicacies like *jadoh* (pork cooked with blood) or vegetarian Sohra pulao at local *kong* (sister) shops

STAY Polo Orchid Resort

GO Fly to Shillong and drive 98 km